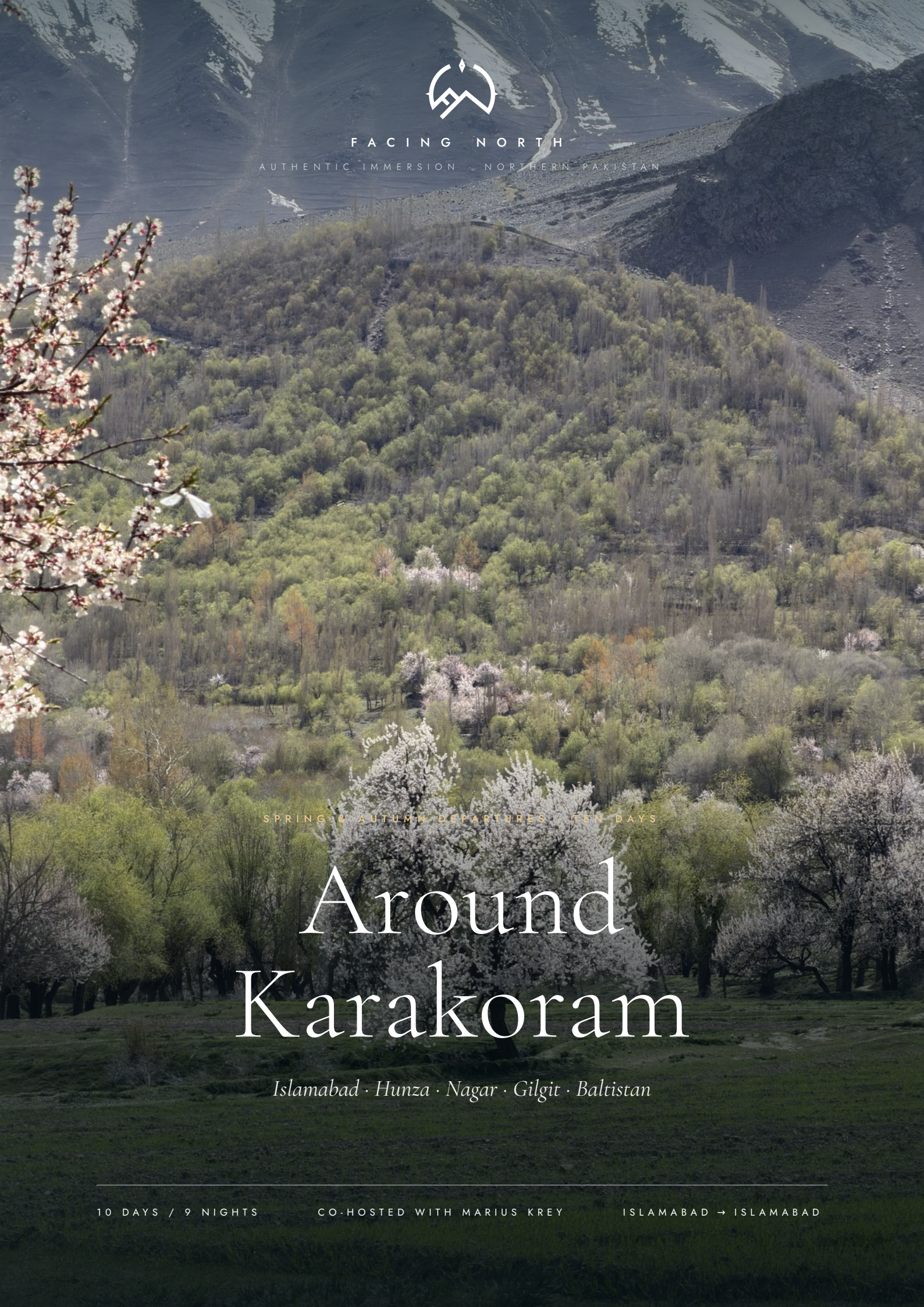


FACING NORTH

AUTHENTIC IMMERSION · NORTHERN PAKISTAN

SPRING & AUTUMN DEPARTURES · TEN DAYS

Around Karakoram

Islamabad · Hunza · Nagar · Gilgit · Baltistan

10 DAYS / 9 NIGHTS | CO-HOSTED WITH MARIUS KREY | ISLAMABAD → ISLAMABAD



Blossom season in the valleys

THE HOOK

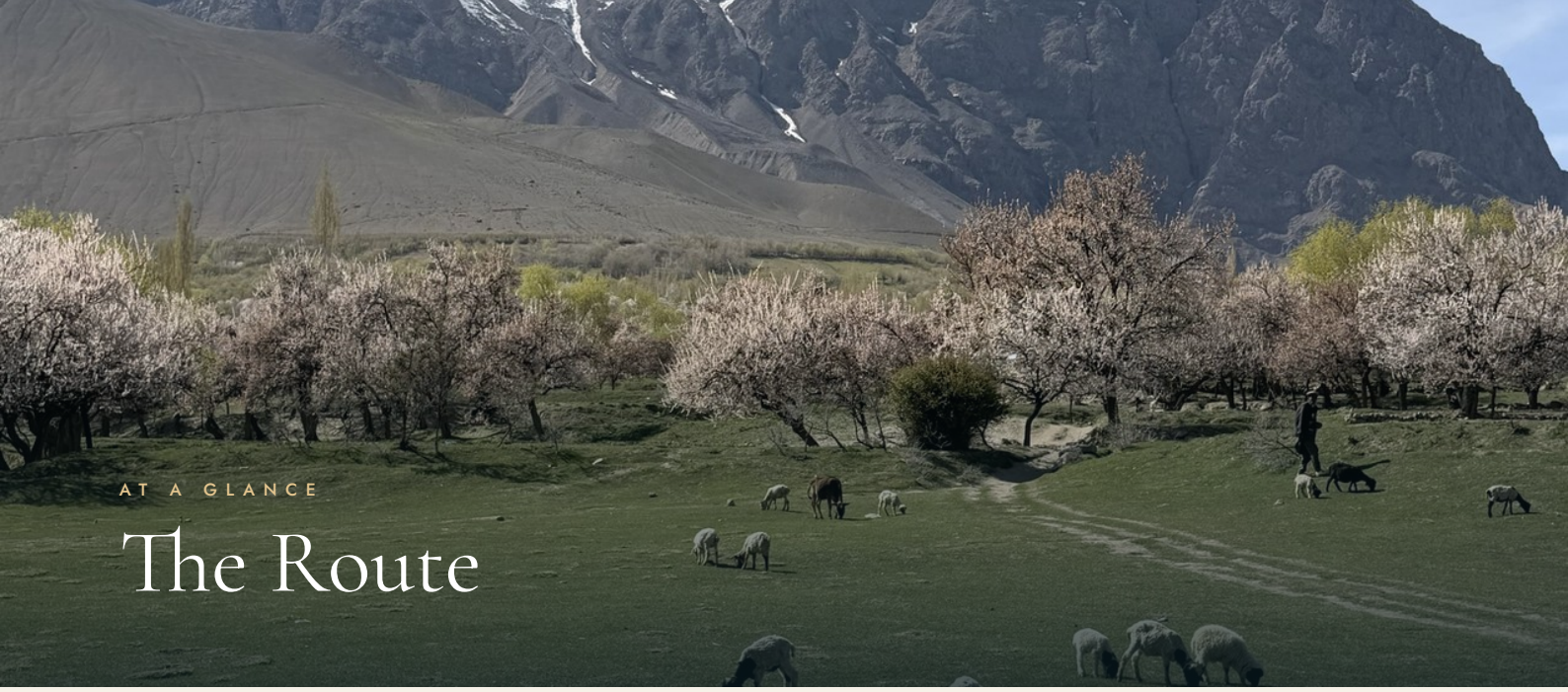
Why this trip exists

Ten days that take you from a capital built in the 1960s to a fort that was already old when it was built, by way of the Karakoram Highway — the paved descendant of the Silk Road — and a cricket ground cut into a mountainside with a 7,788-metre peak standing behind the boundary.

Three valleys, two 400-year-old kitchens, five peaks over seven thousand metres in a single frame — and a film crew with you the whole way, so you come home with the footage as well as the memory.

THE VIBE

PHYSICAL INTENSITY	Comfortable throughout. Two optional short hikes of 30–40 minutes; otherwise forts, lakes and viewpoints reached by vehicle or jeep. No trekking, no camping.
COMFORT LEVEL	Ambience Islamabad, Ambience Hunza, Ramada Gilgit and Khar Resort Skardu — a proper hotel every night, all meals handled, and only four changes of base in ten days.
CULTURAL DEPTH	Burushaski, Shina and Balti valleys back to back. Four forts and palaces spanning a thousand years, two traditional meals cooked by local families, and a live folk night in Hunza.
ROAD TIME	One long transfer on Day 2, Skardu to Hunza, and a three-and-a-half-hour run back down to Skardu on Day 6. Domestic flights at both ends remove everything else.



AT A GLANCE

The Route

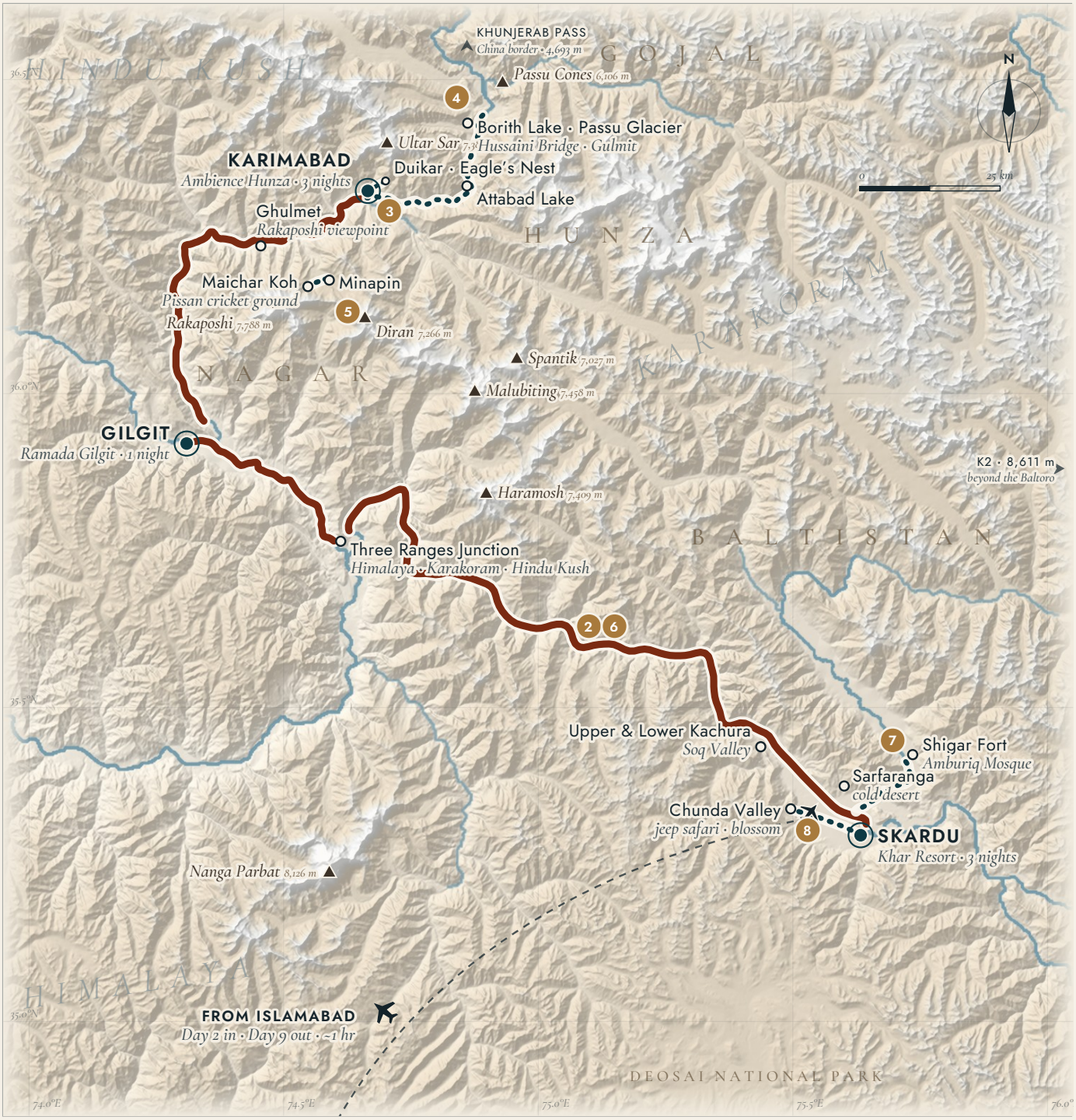
10	4	3	5	2	1
DAYS	HOTELS	VALLEYS	PEAKS OVER 7,000 M	DOMESTIC FLIGHTS	FILM CREW

DAY	WHERE	WHAT	OVERNIGHT
01	Islamabad	*Faisal Mosque, Pakistan Monument, Saidpur*	AMBIENCE ISLAMABAD
02	Skardu → Hunza	*Fly north, then the JSR and the Silk Road*	AMBIENCE HUNZA
03	Central Hunza	*Baltit, Altit, 400-year-old kitchen, Eagle's Nest*	AMBIENCE HUNZA
04	Upper Hunza	*Attabad, Borith, Passu Glacier, Hussaini Bridge*	AMBIENCE HUNZA
05	Nagar → Gilgit	*Maichar Koh cricket ground, stone-pot lunch*	RAMADA GILGIT
06	Gilgit → Skardu	*Soq Valley, speed boating, the Kachura lakes*	KHAR RESORT
07	Shigar Valley	*Shigar Fort, Sarfaranga, K2 Museum, Buddha Rock*	KHAR RESORT
08	Chunda Valley	*Jeep safari to the high pasture, optional polo*	KHAR RESORT
09	Islamabad	*Morning flight, spa day, farewell dinner*	AMBIENCE ISLAMABAD
10	Islamabad	*Breakfast and airport transfer*	DEPARTURE

THE MAP

Three valleys, one loop

Hunza and Nagar on the Karakoram Highway, Baltistan down the Indus — with Islamabad a one-hour flight at either end.



Main road transfer · KKH & Jaglot–Skardu Road

Day excursions & jeep safaris

Domestic flight · Islamabad ↔ Skardu

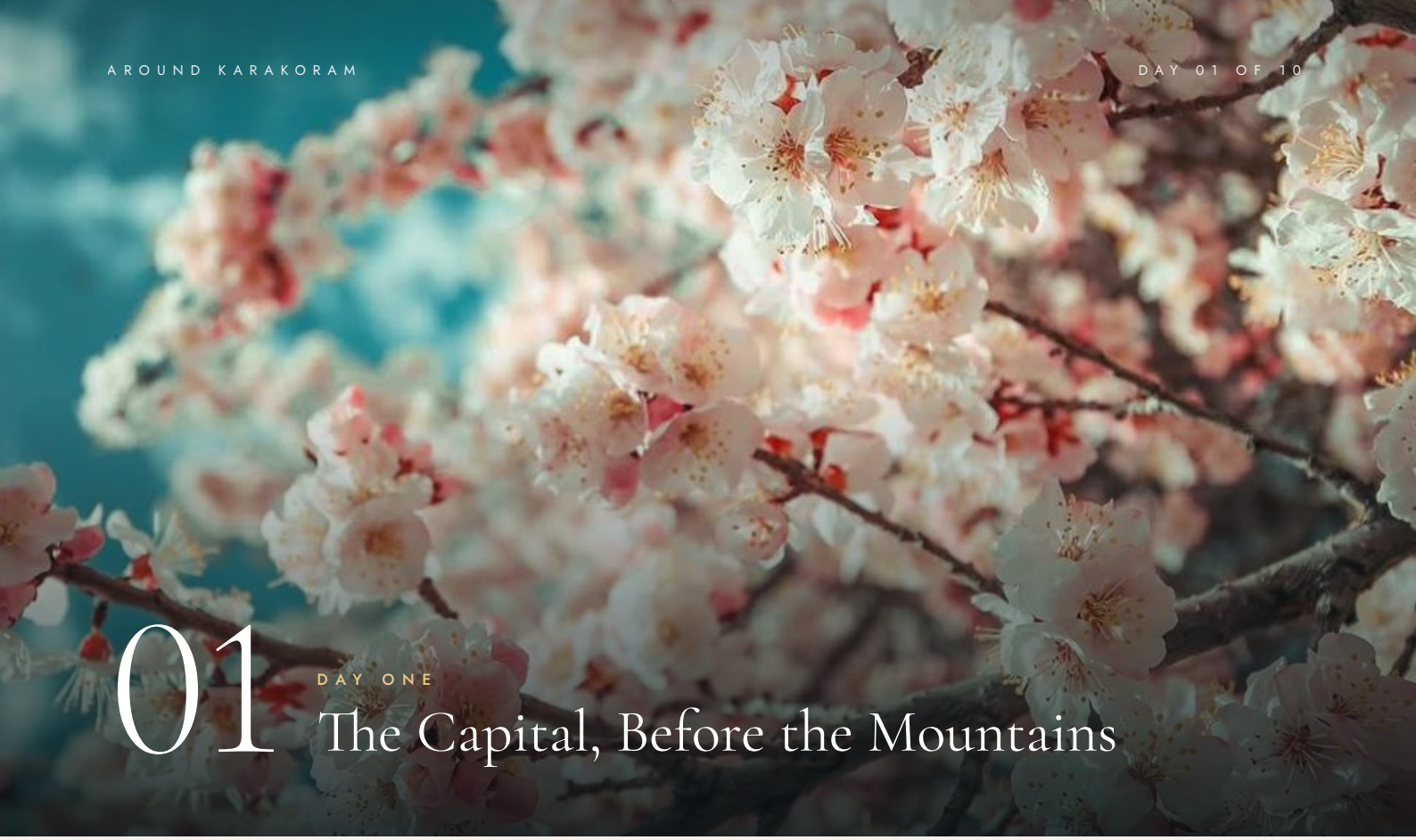
Overnight base

Stop & viewpoint

5 Day number

Relief drawn from elevation data. The dark line is the road you travel; dashed lines are the day trips and jeep safaris out from each base.

Ambience Hotel	Ambience Hunza	Ramada Gilgit	Khar Resort
ISLAMABAD · NIGHTS 1 & 9	KARIMABAD · NIGHTS 2–4	GILGIT · NIGHT 5	SKARDU · NIGHTS 6–8



01 DAY ONE The Capital, Before the Mountains

Faisal Mosque · Pakistan Monument · Saidpur Village · Monal

TRANSFERS	ALTITUDE	MEALS	OVERNIGHT
Included	540 m	Dinner	Ambience Hotel, Islamabad

MORNING

Arrival at Islamabad International. Your guide meets the group in arrivals and the vehicle is already waiting. Transfer to the **Ambience Hotel**, check in, and time to shower off the flight before the city opens up.

AFTERNOON

Faisal Mosque first — Vedat Dalokay's Bedouin-tent design folded into the foot of the Margalla Hills, and one of the largest mosques in the world. Then the **Pakistan Monument** on Shakarparian ridge, four granite petals opening over the city, and **Saidpur Village**, a 500-year-old Mughal-era settlement swallowed whole by the modern capital.

EVENING

Up the Margalla Hills road to **Monal** for the arrival dinner, with Islamabad laid out below you in a grid of lights. Your guide runs the route briefing over dinner. Back to the Ambience for an early night — tomorrow is a dawn flight.

LOGISTICS

Private vehicle with driver from arrivals onward. Islamabad is a 45-minute run from the airport, and the Margalla road up to Monal is sealed the whole way.

SECRET SPOT

On one small courtyard in Saidpur stand a Hindu temple, a Sikh gurdwara and a mosque, side by side and still standing. It is a two-minute walk off the restaurant terrace everyone else photographs, and nobody points it out.

DAY TWO

02 Over the Mountains, Then Along the Silk Road

Islamabad → Skardu by air · Jaglot–Skardu Road · Karakoram Highway · Hunza

FLIGHT	DRIVE	MEALS	OVERNIGHT
~1 hr	6–6.5 hrs	B · L · D	Ambience Hotel, Hunza

MORNING

An early morning flight north. On a clear day this is one of the great aerial approaches anywhere — the Indus unspooling below, **Nanga Parbat** (8,126 m) close off the wing, and the Karakoram stacked along the horizon all the way in. At Skardu, your northern team is waiting with traditional caps and a proper local welcome — not a sign and a handshake, the real thing.

AFTERNOON

Then the drive that sets up the whole trip. The **Jaglot–Skardu Road** runs the Indus gorge before joining the **Karakoram Highway**, the paved descendant of the Silk Road itself. A relaxed lunch on the way, then two stops worth the clock: the **Nanga Parbat viewpoint**, and the restored **ruins of the old Silk Road**, conserved by AKRSP and the Aga Khan Foundation, where the caravan track is still legible in the rock.

EVENING

Last stop before the valley: the **Rakaposhi viewpoint** at Ghulmet, where the 27th-highest peak in the world rises almost six vertical kilometres out of the valley floor. Then the orchards start and you arrive at the **Ambience Hotel, Hunza** in Karimabad. Hot shower, dinner at the hotel, and an early night.

LOGISTICS

Domestic flight Islamabad → Skardu included. Private vehicle with driver for the full transfer, broken into comfortable legs.



The welcome at Skardu

LOCAL INTERACTION

The cap you are handed at Skardu is not a souvenir — it is worn. Ask your guide how it is folded for your age and which valley the pattern belongs to. In Hunza it marks you as a guest of the house rather than a tourist, and people notice.

OUR ADVICE · ALTITUDE

You go from 540 m to 2,500 m in a single day. Nothing here is high enough to be dangerous, but drink more water than feels necessary for the first forty-eight hours.



03 DAY THREE — A Thousand Years of Central Hunza

Baltit Fort · Karimabad Bazaar · Altit Fort · Eagle's Nest

ON FOOT	DUIKAR	MEALS	OVERNIGHT
Easy · ~4 km	2,850 m	B · L · D	Ambience Hotel, Hunza

MORNING

Up through the old lanes to **Baltit Fort**, seat of the Mirs of Hunza for seven hundred years, restored by the Aga Khan Trust for Culture. Then the old **Karimabad Bazaar** — raw gemstones, apricot-kernel oil, hand-knitted caps — with a stop for walnut cake and apricot cake, which Hunza does better than anywhere.

AFTERNOON

Lunch is the centrepiece: a **400-year-old house** where a local family curates a full traditional Hunza table — chapshuro, diram phitti, hoi garma, apricot soup and mulberry tea, served in the original rooms. Then a slow stroll into **Altit Fort**, at roughly 1,100 years the oldest standing monument in Gilgit-Baltistan.

EVENING

Climb to **Duikar — the Eagle's Nest** for the panorama the valley is famous for: five peaks above seven thousand metres in one frame — Rakaposhi, Malubiting, Ultar Sar, Diran and Spantik — with Lady Finger spiking up in front. Back at the Ambience Hotel, a **traditional musical night**: rubab, damal drums and Burushaski folk song, played live over dinner.



The old lanes below Altit

SECRET SPOT

Twenty minutes below Karimabad lies Ganish Khun — a 1,000-year-old walled village of carved wooden mosques, watchtowers and a communal bathing pool, with a UNESCO conservation award to its name and a fraction of Baltit's visitors.

LOGISTICS

Mostly on foot through Karimabad and Altit, with the vehicle for short hops. The Duikar road is a series of tight switchbacks and is driven, not walked.



DAY FOUR

04 Upper Hunza — Ice, Turquoise and a Rope Bridge

Attabad Lake · Borith Lake · Passu Glacier · Hussaini Bridge · Passu Cones

HIKE	DRIVE	MEALS	OVERNIGHT
30–40 min each way	~120 km return	B · L · D	Ambience Hotel, Hunza

MORNING

North into Gojal, the Wakhi-speaking upper valley. **Attabad Lake** comes first — twenty-one kilometres of impossible turquoise created by the landslide of January 2010. Through the five Pak–China Friendship Tunnels that replaced the drowned road, then up to **Borith Lake** (2,600 m), on the migratory flyway.

AFTERNOON

From Borith, a 30–40 minute hike to the snout of the **Passu Glacier** — white ice, grinding and cracking, close enough to feel the cold coming off it. Down then to the **Hussaini Suspension Bridge**: cable, missing planks, and the Hunza River moving fast underneath. Crossing is optional and so is the zip line; watching from the bank is a perfectly respectable choice.

EVENING

On to the **Passu Cones** — the Tupopdan ridge at 6,106 m, the most photographed skyline in Pakistan. A late lunch at the **Yak Grill**, then stay for the hour the light runs along the cones, the shot the whole day is built around. Back to the Ambience for the last dinner in the valley.

LOGISTICS

Private vehicle all day on sealed KKH tarmac. The glacier walk is entirely optional; the vehicle waits at Borith either way.



Lunch beside Borith Lake

LOCAL INTERACTION

In Gulmit, the Bulbulik Heritage Music School teaches Wakhi children the old valley songs on rubab and ghazhek. Drop in between classes and they will usually play one. No ticket, no schedule — your guide calls ahead.

OUR ADVICE · GEAR

The Passu Glacier walk and the Hussaini Bridge both want proper shoes with grip. Everything else is doable in trainers — this is not the day to find out your soles are smooth.



05 DAY FIVE Rakaposhi from the Cricket Ground

Karimabad → Minapin · Maichar Koh / Pissan · Nagar → Gilgit

JEEP SAFARI	DRIVE	MEALS	OVERNIGHT
Included	~3 hrs total	B · L · D	Ramada Gilgit

MORNING

Early start south into Nagar Valley and the old village of **Minapin**, where the vehicle hands over to jeeps. The climb to **Maichar Koh — the Pissan natural cricket ground** — ends at a full-size pitch cut into a high shelf of the mountain, with **Rakaposhi** (7,788 m) standing directly behind the boundary and the ridge running east to Diran. There is no hurry here.

AFTERNOON

Back down to Minapin for the second of the trip's great meals: a **traditional Nagar lunch** prepared by the village, cooked with local spices and entirely organic, the meat slow-cooked in a **400-year-old stone pot** to recipes that have not changed in generations. Aromatic, unhurried and not on any menu.

EVENING

Rejoin the Karakoram Highway south for **Gilgit**, the old crossroads of the Karakoram, the Himalaya and the Hindu Kush. Check in at the **Ramada Gilgit**, dinner, and a quiet night.



The stone-pot lunch in Nagar

LOCAL INTERACTION

If there is a match on at Pissan, the village will wave you in. Nagar takes its cricket seriously, and visitors tend to be handed tea and a place on the boundary wall within four minutes of arriving.

LOGISTICS

Private vehicle Karimabad → Minapin → Gilgit, with 4x4 jeeps for the Minapin ↔ Maichar Koh leg, which no road vehicle climbs. Jeep safari included.



06 DAY SIX
Down the Indus to Baltistan

Gilgit → Skardu · Soq Valley · Upper & Lower Kachura

DRIVE	ALTITUDE	MEALS	OVERNIGHT
~3.5 hrs	2,230 m	B · L · D	Khar Resort, Skardu

MORNING

Breakfast at the Ramada, then east onto the **Jaglot–Skardu Road** — three and a half hours of Indus gorge, with sheer rock on one side, grey glacial water on the other, and almost nothing in between. One of the great drives in Asia, and it earns every minute.

AFTERNOON

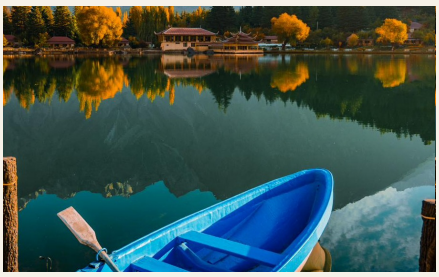
Into Baltistan and straight to **Soq Valley**, where white-water streams come down off the mountain in braided channels through a green shelf of pasture. Tea and snacks are set up beside the water. Then **Upper Kachura Lake** for speed boating on cold, clear snowmelt — included in your package — with an optional zip line across the water. Lunch at **Lower Kachura — Shangri-La**, where the old gardens run right down to the lake.

EVENING

Short transfer out to **Khar Resort**, your base for the next three nights. Check in, and the pace of the trip drops a gear. Dinner at the resort and an unhurried evening.

LOGISTICS

Private Toyota Grand Cabin with driver the full day. Speed boating at Upper Kachura is included; the zip line is run by a local operator and paid on site if anyone wants it.



Lower Kachura — Shangri-La

SECRET SPOT

From Upper Kachura a footpath drops toward the Indus channel in about ten minutes. Almost everyone shoots the lake from the near shore and turns back; the frame from down there — water in front, Karakoram behind — is the better one.



DAY SEVEN

07 Shigar Valley — Fort, Desert, Museum, Buddha

Shigar Fort · Sarfaranga Cold Desert · K2 Museum · Manthal Buddha Rock

DRIVE	PACE	MEALS	OVERNIGHT
~45 min each way	Light	B · L · D	Khar Resort, Skardu

MORNING

A full day in the Shigar Valley, starting with **Shigar Fort** — Fong Khar, the Palace on the Rock. The 17th-century seat of the Raja of Shigar, restored over seven years by the Aga Khan Trust for Culture: carved wooden chambers, courtyard gardens, and shade and seating the whole way round.

AFTERNOON

Out onto the **Sarfaranga Cold Desert**, one of the highest cold deserts on earth — white dunes running straight into the Karakoram wall, reached entirely by vehicle. Lunch, then back into Skardu for the **K2 Museum**: the expeditions, the Balti porters who carried them, and the gear that came back off the Savage Mountain.

EVENING

The **Manthal Buddha Rock**, a nine-metre standing Buddha carved into a granite boulder in the 8th century, when this valley was Buddhist. Then a little leisure in the **Skardu bazaar** — dried apricots, gemstones and Balti woollens — before dinner at Khar Resort.

LOGISTICS

Private Grand Cabin. If the group would rather catch Sarfaranga at sunset, say so in the morning and we flip the order — the dunes turn copper in the last hour of light.



Inside the old forts

SECRET SPOT

Ten minutes from Shigar Fort stands the Amburiq Mosque, built in the 14th century by Kashmiri craftsmen — the oldest mosque in Baltistan, with a UNESCO Asia-Pacific award. No car park, no ticket desk, usually nobody there.



08 DAY EIGHT Up to Chunda

Jeep safari to Chunda Valley · Skardu · optional polo

JEEP SAFARI	PACE	MEALS	OVERNIGHT
Included	Easy	B · L · D	Khar Resort, Skardu

MORNING

The jeeps come for you after breakfast. **Chunda Valley** sits high above the Skardu basin, a broad shelf of pasture and orchard reached by a track no road vehicle attempts. The valley opens onto a view of the Indus, the Shigar confluence and the whole basin at once — and in spring, the **apricot and cherry blossom** comes through in waves of white and pink against bare rock and snow.

AFTERNOON

Time up there is left deliberately loose — walk the orchard terraces, sit with the view, let the content creator work. Back down to Skardu for a late lunch. If there is a **polo match** on at the Skardu ground, we go: Gilgit-Baltistan plays the old free-style game with almost no rules, a live band on the sidelines, and a crowd that takes it extremely seriously.

EVENING

The rest of the day is yours at **Khar Resort** — the last afternoon in the mountains, and the right one to do nothing with. Dinner at the resort.

LOGISTICS

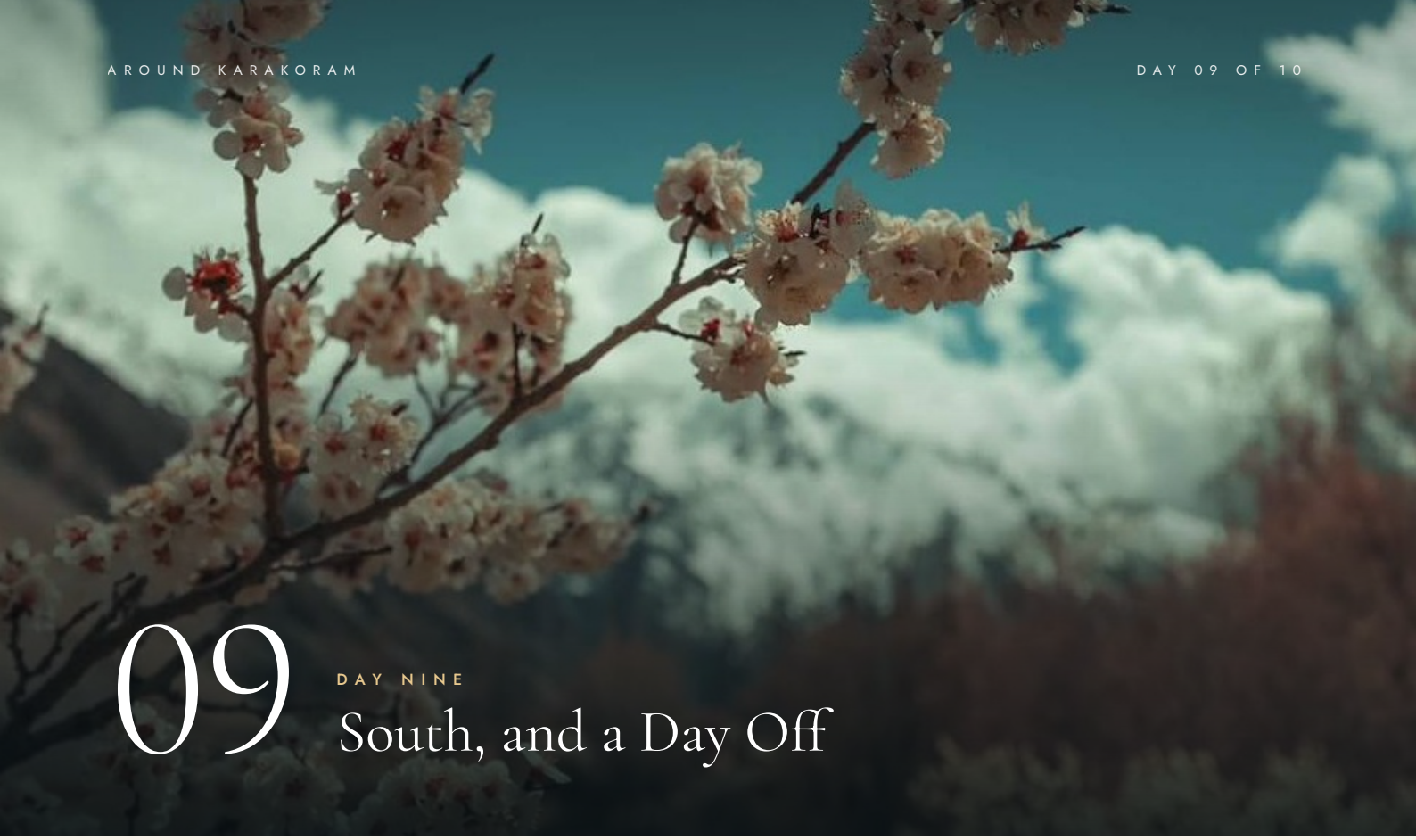
4x4 jeep safari included for the climb to Chunda and back. The road is rough, the jeeps are not, and the whole thing is done seated.

LOCAL INTERACTION

Free-style polo is the real thing here, not a demonstration for visitors. There is no fixture list we can promise in advance, so your guide checks the week you arrive. If a match is on, it is the most alive hour you will spend in Baltistan.

OUR ADVICE · SEASONALITY

Chunda is at its most spectacular from late March to early May, when the blossom comes through. In autumn the same terraces turn gold and the view over the Indus basin is at its clearest.



09 DAY NINE — South, and a Day Off

Skardu → Islamabad by air · Leisure & spa · Farewell dinner

FLIGHT	AFTERNOON	MEALS	OVERNIGHT
~1 hr	At leisure	B · L · D	Ambience Hotel, Islamabad

MORNING

Early breakfast at the resort, then the short transfer to Skardu airport for the **one-hour flight back to Islamabad** — the same mountains you have spent a week inside, laid out beneath you on the way out. Our Islamabad team meets the group at arrivals.

AFTERNOON

Straight to the **Ambience Hotel**, freshen up, and then the day is deliberately empty: **leisure, and the spa** if you want it. A long lunch, the pool, or nothing at all. After eight days of mountain roads, this is the day everybody ends up grateful for.

EVENING

A **farewell dinner** at one of Islamabad's best tables, chosen to suit the group, with your guide and the content creator handing over the **first cut of the film** and stills from the journey.

LOGISTICS

Domestic flight Skardu → Islamabad included, with meet-and-greet at arrivals and private transfers at both ends. Spa treatments are booked on the day and settled directly.



A recent Facing North group in Hunza

LOCAL KNOWLEDGE

If anyone still wants to shop, Jinnah Super and Kohsar Market are twenty minutes away and open late — carpets, pashmina, gemstones and dried fruit at capital prices rather than airport ones.



10 DAY TEN Homeward

Ambience Hotel → Islamabad International (ISB)

TRANSFER	ENDS	MEALS	OVERNIGHT
~45 min	At the airport	Breakfast	Tour concludes

MORNING

Breakfast at the hotel and check out at a time that suits your flight. Private transfer to **Islamabad International**, with your guide staying until the group is through check-in.

AFTERNOON

The complete **photo and video package** travels home with you — ten days, three valleys, four forts, five peaks over seven thousand metres, and a set of memories to cherish.

LOGISTICS

Private Grand Cabin with driver for the airport transfer. Guide in attendance through check-in.

LOCAL KNOWLEDGE

If your flight is late in the day, tell us in advance — we hold day-use rooms and add a short Margalla Hills loop rather than leave anybody sitting on a suitcase in a lobby.

IN THE FIELD

Small groups, real people

Every Facing North departure travels with the same core: a guide who grew up in these valleys, a driver who knows every bend of the Indus, a co-host who has done the route, and a content creator who makes sure you spend the trip looking at the mountains rather than your phone.



Under the Passu Cones, Upper Hunza



The content creator at work, Karimabad

THE FINE PRINT, UPFRONT

Inclusions & Exclusions

WHAT IS INCLUDED

- **Nine nights' accommodation**
  Ambience Hotel Islamabad (2), Ambience Hotel Hunza (3), Ramada Gilgit (1), Khar Resort Skardu (3)
- **Domestic flights**
  Islamabad → Skardu and Skardu → Islamabad
- **All meals, arrival to departure**
  9 breakfasts, 8 lunches and 9 dinners — Day 1 is the arrival dinner only; Day 10 is breakfast only
- **All transportation**
  Private Toyota Grand Cabin with driver for ten days — fuel, tolls, parking and airport transfers
- **English-speaking guide**
  With the group for the entire journey
- **Co-hosted with Marius Krey**
  Travelling with the group from start to finish
- **Dedicated content creator**
  Professional video and photography, delivered as a finished package
- **Traditional musical night**
  Live Burushaski folk music at the Ambience Hotel, Hunza
- **Two heritage kitchens**
  The 400-year-old house in Karimabad and the stone-pot lunch in Nagar
- **Jeep safaris**
  Chunda Valley and Maichar Koh / Pissan cricket ground
- **All entry tickets and site permits**
  Baltit, Altit, Shigar Fort, the K2 Museum, Manthal Buddha Rock and every other site on the itinerary
- **Speed boating**
  At Upper Kachura Lake on Day 6
- **Visa documentation support**
  Invitation letter and supporting paperwork
- **Traditional welcome**
  Caps and a proper greeting from our northern team at Skardu

WHAT IS NOT

- International flights to and from Islamabad
- Pakistan visa fees — we prepare the documentation, you pay the fee
- Travel and medical insurance — strongly recommended
- Optional activities — zip lines at Upper Kachura and Hussaini Bridge, polo match entry
- Spa and wellness treatments on Day 9
- Lunch on Day 1, and lunch and dinner on Day 10
- Beverages outside the included meals
- Laundry, telephone, paid Wi-Fi and personal items
- Personal shopping and souvenirs
- Tips for guide, driver and crew, at your discretion
- Medical costs, evacuation and rescue
- Costs from landslides, road closures, weather or flight delays
- Anything not explicitly listed as included





Marius at work above Karimabad

YOUR CO-HOST

Travelling with Marius

This departure is co-hosted with **Marius Krey**, a travel and outdoor content creator from Germany who travels with the group from start to finish — not a guest dropping in for a day, but alongside you on every road, every fort and every meal.

HOW HE FOUND IT	Marius came to Northern Pakistan to retrace the route this itinerary is built on, and saw every site on it for himself — Hunza and Nagar, the forts, the Karakoram Highway, Baltistan and the lakes. He came away calling it one of the best and most underrated places he has travelled to recently.
WHY HE HOSTS IT	He wanted other people to see it. That is the whole pitch: no sponsorship angle, no brand activation — a creator who found somewhere worth showing people and decided to bring them.
WHAT IT MEANS FOR YOU	A European host who has done the route and knows what a first-time visitor to Pakistan actually worries about, travelling with a local team who have done it a hundred times.
BLOSSOM SEASON	Marius hosts the spring departures in particular — late March into April, when the apricot and cherry orchards of Hunza, Nagar and Chunda come through pink and white against bare rock and snow.
IN FRONT OF THE CAMERA	Marius shoots as he travels and works alongside the dedicated content creator, so you come home with a film and stills nobody in the group had to stop and take.

WHEN TO TRAVEL

Built for spring and autumn

Two windows, and it is honest to say so: spring blossom and autumn colour — the two times of year the valleys do something the photographs cannot quite prepare you for, with clear skies and comfortable temperatures on every road in this plan.



Spring

LATE MARCH – MAY

Blossom season, and the reason most people pick this departure. The apricot and cherry orchards of Hunza, Nagar and Chunda Valley come through in waves of pink and white against bare rock and snow, usually from the last week of March through April. Day 8 in Chunda is at its absolute best. Cool, clear and quiet before the summer crowds.



Autumn

SEPTEMBER – OCTOBER

The photographers' season. The same orchards turn gold and deep red, the air is the clearest it gets all year, and the peaks come out sharp enough to count the ridgelines. Warm days, cold nights, and the best light of the twelve months on every viewpoint in this plan.

WHICH ONE TO CHOOSE

Spring if you want colour in the foreground — blossom, green terraces, meltwater running hard. Autumn if you want the mountains themselves: gold valleys, hard blue skies and the sharpest peak views of the year. Spring runs slightly cooler; autumn gives slightly more reliable flying weather into Skardu.

OUTSIDE THESE WINDOWS

The route can be operated in summer and winter on request, but it is not what this itinerary was built for. If you are coming once, come in spring or autumn.

FACING NORTH RECOMMENDS CHOOSING YOUR WINDOW

Pick spring for blossom and autumn for gold and the sharpest peaks. Autumn is the safer bet on flying weather into Skardu; spring is the prettier one at ground level. Either way, book early — both windows are short, and the blossom moves by a week or two every year.



FACING NORTH

Raw adventure, properly looked after.

A spring & autumn journey through Northern Pakistan, co-hosted with Marius Krey

Ten days · Nine nights · Islamabad to Islamabad

FACINGNORTHTRAVELS.COM

PRIVATE & GROUP JOURNEYS IN NORTHERN PAKISTAN